

# GALLANT IAS ACADEMY

## PRELIMS CUM MAINS BATCH 2027

### ANCIENT INDIA

### MODULE 4

### JAINISM - SUMMARY (NCERT)

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Jainism is an ancient Shramana tradition systematised - not founded - by Mahavira. It explains bondage through karma and liberation through disciplined personal effort, non-violence and renunciation.

#### 1. Origins and Core Doctrine

##### Historical setting

- **Changing world:** In the mid-first millennium BCE, new kingdoms, towns, trade networks and social groups were developing in the Ganga valley. These changes generated new questions about life, death, rebirth and social order.
- **Intellectual challenge:** Mahavira and other teachers questioned Vedic authority and ritual sacrifice. They stressed individual agency: birth, caste or gender need not alone determine one's spiritual possibility.
- **Balanced interpretation:** Do not reduce Jainism to merely a 'reaction against Brahmanism'. It emerged from wider debates involving Vedic, Upanishadic, Ajivika, materialist and other Shramana traditions.

##### Tirthankaras and Mahavira

- **Continuity:** Jaina philosophy existed before Vardhamana. Jaina tradition recognises 24 Tirthankaras - ford-makers who guide beings across the river of existence.
- **Key teachers:** Rishabhanatha is regarded as the first Tirthankara; Parshvanatha as the 23rd; Vardhamana Mahavira, a sixth-century BCE contemporary of the Buddha, as the 24th.
- **Mahavira:** Born in the Vajji-Vaishali region to a Kshatriya family, he renounced worldly life, practised severe asceticism, attained kevala-jnana (perfect knowledge), taught as a Jina ('conqueror') and attained nirvana at Pavapuri. Exact dates remain debated.

##### Worldview: bondage and liberation

- **Jiva and ajiva:** Reality comprises conscious souls (jiva) and non-conscious categories (ajiva). NCERT highlights the radical claim that the entire world is animated - including plants, water, stones and minute forms of life.
- **Karma and samsara:** Karma is not only moral consequence; it is conceived as subtle matter that attaches to the soul through passions and actions, producing repeated birth and rebirth.
- **Moksha:** Stopping new karmic influx (samvara) and shedding accumulated karma (nirjara) reveals the soul's inherent infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and energy. The liberated soul rises beyond rebirth.
- **Religious character:** Jainism is non-theistic: it does not depend on a creator God for salvation. Tirthankaras are revered as perfected exemplars, not creators of the universe.

##### Path to liberation

- **Three Jewels (Ratnatraya):** Right faith, right knowledge and right conduct must operate together; knowledge without ethical discipline cannot free the soul.
- **Five vows:** Ahimsa (non-injury), satya (truth), asteya (non-stealing), brahmacharya (celibacy/chastity) and aparigraha (non-possession). Monastics observe them as mahavratas; lay followers practise limited anuvratas.
- **Ascetic ideal:** Penance, fasting, control of mind and senses, and detachment remove karma. In the strict doctrine reflected by NCERT, final liberation requires renunciation; lay ethics prepare the aspirant for it.

## 2. Organisation, Spread and Significance

### Distinctive philosophical ideas

- **Ahimsa:** Extends beyond humans to animals, plants and microscopic life. It governs food, occupation, speech and intention, and became Jainism's most enduring influence on Indian ethical thought.
- **Anekantavada:** Reality is many-sided; a single statement captures only one standpoint. This encourages intellectual humility without claiming that every view is equally true.
- **Syadvada:** Judgments are conditional - 'from a certain standpoint'. It is the logical method associated with anekantavada; it is not simple indecision or relativism.
- **Aparigraha:** Attachment and accumulation bind the soul. The principle links spiritual discipline with restrained consumption and ecological ethics.

### Community, language and spread

- **Fourfold community:** The order included monks, nuns, laymen (shravakas) and laywomen (shravikas). This linked a demanding monastic path with a durable lay support system.
- **Communication:** Teachings circulated in Prakrits such as Ardhamagadhi rather than remaining confined to elite Sanskrit. Jaina scholars later produced major works in Prakrit, Sanskrit, Tamil, Kannada and Gujarati.
- **Regional strength:** Jainism spread from the middle Ganga region into western and southern India. Merchant support, monastic networks, temple libraries and patronage by several dynasties sustained it.

### Svetambara and Digambara:

| Issue                   | Svetambara                                  | Digambara                                                       |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Monastic ideal</b>   | White-robed monks and nuns                  | Fully initiated male monks follow the sky-clad ideal            |
| <b>Scriptures</b>       | Accepts an Agama canon, redacted at Valabhi | Holds that the original canon was lost                          |
| <b>Women and moksha</b> | Women can attain liberation                 | Traditional doctrine requires rebirth as male before liberation |
| <b>Images</b>           | May be clothed and ornamented               | Usually nude, austere and unornamented                          |

### Texts, culture and historical contribution

- **Literature:** Agamas/Angas, Acharanga Sutra, Uttaradhyayana Sutra, Kalpa Sutra and Umasvati's Tattvartha Sutra are major reference points. NCERT notes that manuscripts were preserved for centuries in temple libraries.
- **Art and architecture:** Early Tirthankara sculptures, Udayagiri-Khandagiri caves, the Jain caves at Ellora, Dilwara and Ranakpur temples, and the Gommateshwara image at Shravanabelagola illustrate a rich tradition.
- **Wider legacy:** Jain thinkers enriched logic, epistemology, literature and mathematics; lay communities supported trade, learning, charity and manuscript preservation. Ahimsa and aparigraha retain contemporary ethical relevance.
- **Why it endured:** A disciplined monastic order, economically active lay community, use of regional languages, adaptable temple culture and strong regional patronage created institutional continuity.
- **Limits:** Severe ascetic demands restricted mass appeal; royal patronage was uneven; sectarian differentiation and competition from Buddhism and Brahmanical-bhakti traditions narrowed its geographical reach. Yet Jainism did not disappear.